# Tied up in Chains

## By Laura Henry

**SAUL MANTHONY DEGROUP:** When God speaks to you, you don't tell him He'll have to wait. You sit back down and you listen.

## INTRODUCTION

*Scripture tells us that "it is not for [us] to know the times or dates the Father has set by His own authority." But, it'd be much more convenient if we could prepare ourselves for when he was coming to visit. Then we wouldn't be preoccupied or at work or…in the shower… "Tied up in Chains" by Laura Henry.*

**SAUL MANTHONY DEGROUP:** He spoke to me last night. I had my ears open wide for nine years and eleven months and I was plannin on closing them on the anniversary of the decade. But he must have been listening to my thoughts. 'Cause he got right up to the cutoff date and then it happened. He spoke. The first time it happened I was an ordinary guy. I was sitting on this big rock underneath this big blue sky. Feeling the warm air. Everything so lovely, thinking about Armageddon.

You know Armageddon don't you? The battle in the sky? It's that time when God comes down and fights the evil on our black planet. There's a big rain, drops of blood that feels like fire, but it ain't no pain compared to what we got down here, even on the good days. And there's a song in the air and a big white smoke and we all, the babies and the mothers and the folks who spend their days toilin' on the earth for a dime and no respect, all get wrapped up

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in the arms of God. And we fly through the air up to him in his heavens laughing and shouting and the Great Chant goes up Arma, Arma, Arma Geddon. Just like that. Arma, Arma, Arma Geddon. And all of us peoples are saved. The earthly peoples, swept up into the sky singing. And we are free at last, free and happy and there is no pain.

I was high up there, that first day, high on the beauty of the rapture of my thoughts when it happened. Oh, no. He didn't speak to me yet. Not yet. But I heard the break bell clanging, and it was time to go back to work again.
And right there, coming through the noise of the break bell was when it started, a strange sound. A small sound at first, a little hum, so tiny at the start that I didn't even notice. I stood up, and it got a little louder, and as I walked back towards the shop, the noise shaped itself into sounds that began to shape themselves into words and then suddenly I could hear the words. A voice from nowhere talking to me loud and clearlike.

The voice said, "Saul Manthoney Degroup, I am talking to you." I knew the voice. It stopped me in my tracks, But I said, "Who are you?" just to check. And then He spoke. And he said, "It is me. The Great One. And Saul Manthoney, just like the Saul before you, I have come calling." I couldn't believe it. I said, "God?" And he said, "It is me" and I said, "I'm gonna be late to work. Do you realize that? I've been sittin here on a bench thinking about you through my whole lunch hour and now it's over and now you want to talk." And he said, "Yes, Saul Manthoney. I don't always call at the most convenient time."

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When God speaks to you, you don't tell him He'll have to wait. You sit back down and you listen. And that's exactly what I did. I put my butt back down and got ready to receive His word. And He said to me, "Saul, you've got things to do. You go to work now that is what you should do but keep your ears open to me. Keep those ears in your heart open. Because I'm coming back. You are my blessed child. I am choosing you to spread my word in Venezuela." And then he left again just like that.

So I went to work, but I'm sayin' right now, I couldn't keep a clear head. I just kept thinking, "Jesus is coming. Jesus is coming to me, Saul Manthoney, just like he came to the other Saul. He's calling to me." I felt more special inside then than I ever felt in my entire life.

When I got home I cleaned the place. I put on a nice shirt and my good shoes. I combed my hair neat and settled down, ready to receive God's word. He was late. I couldn't help but watch the clock. Eight thirty, nine, nine forty-five...1 read my Bible, clock hands still moving. I took a walk. I sang. It got later. No voice. I stayed up through the night, listening and praying. Two-thirty, two forty-five, three and work in the morning still to come. But He didn't come back. Maybe He just got too busy, I thought. Maybe he was too busy for a man like me. And then I remembered, he didn't say when he was coming back, he just said to keep my ears open. Maybe he wasn't coming back for a while. Maybe there was something I had to learn first, a test, to prove myself. And I thought of the other part of what he said. I was sent to spread his word in Venezuela. Venezuela? I knew I had to follow Him, so I

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left all my earthly possessions, cashed in all the money I had in the world and picked up and went to Venezuela on a plane through the night.

How I got to Venezuela is another story. We don't have time for that one. You're here to receive God's new letter for the Next Millennium. I'm holding it right here in my hands. God gave it to me and now I am here to give it to you. It is my greatest mission in life.

I've been here ten years, to the day. It wasn't easy at first. I didn't have any money, no place to go. I didn't even know how to speak right. Ohee, I was scared when I came here. Boy, was I scared. But God always has us in his hands and he took care of me and slowly, I learnt to say what I needed to say and I ended up in this place along the Rio Orinico and was taken in by some nice folks. I told them my story, that God had sent me, and they let me stay there so I could tell stories for God, just the way I'm telling you today. And soon I was going all over to tell my stories and people were coming from allover to hear them. They wanted to receive joy. And they seemed to get it. But I can tell you now that the whole time I was preaching like a called man, I felt like a fake. A crazy man singing about Armageddon and the word of God. 'Cause God never spoke to me again. These last ten years, I've been waiting with my ears open and my heart wide, singing the praises of God. And He never again let me receive His word. Not like the first time.

Was I a fake? I didn't know. I would plead with him and plead with him. God, I'd pray, give me a sign. Let me know you're here, that I'm not some crazy

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man in a new land with a grand delusion. Let me know you sent me here. Still, no word. And I kept preachin' and talkin', telling people about the word of God, but all the time, doubting bigger than Thomas. Am I a fake? If I'm not why won't you come back? Please, please come back. Still, no word.

Until last night. There I was, an ordinary man on an ordinary day. I'd finished my preaching for the night and had just stepped into the bathtub, ready to take myself a hot shower and the water was on, streaming down me, and I was singing songs as loud as I could when I heard this still small voice that I recalled from those other days. Soft at first, but this time I knew for sure what it was. I stopped. "God?" I said? "It is me, my son," he said back. "God," I said, "Can't you see I'm in the shower?" He laughed and said, "Saul, my child. I love you. I'll come back at a better time." "Oh, no you don't," I said. "You said that last time and I've been waitin' for ten whole years. I'll be danged if I'm gonna miss you cause I'm taking a bath. Talk to me. Talk to me now." And he said, "But Saul, you're all wet. I'm going to need you to be ready with a piece of paper. You're going to take dictation for me. You're going to write a letter that will beat the great letters of Paul." To miss this chance, what a fool I would have been.

I'm ready, God. I'm ready right now. And I stepped out of the shower, all soaped up and everything and I put a towel around my middle and I found some paper and I sat my butt down on the chair and I waited for him to speak again. And you know what? He waited for me too. For me. Saul Manthoney Degroup. He waited until I was situated and then he began to

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speak again. It came in spurts. I'd listen, he'd say a little. I'd write. He'd say a little more, I'd write. I didn't question a thing, just wrote it down, wrote down every word he said. It took all night. I'm a little tired now, if I must say so myself. It's a rough job, being secretary for the Lord. But now I got it-my letter-just as inspired as the letters from Paul, and I have come here to read it to you today.

At first I was a little nervous. I read it over just a few minutes ago, you see, and I know that some of what I have to say to you might seem a little crazy. I can't help it. I didn't come up with the idea. It's all God's thoughts. I just held the pen. So don't judge, if you start to feel like the words come out a little bit strange. Hold on till the end of the message. It is God's great message to me and to you, my friends. The answer to all our prayers, everything we've been waiting for since the last letters from Him. It's the New Letter for the Next Millennium. Hold on to your seats. Close your eyes. Open your hearts. Get ready to receive his word. *(Saul takes hold of his letter and begins to speak.)* Dear friends: Kiss someone you love when you receive this letter. With love all things are possible. *(He stops suddenly)*

Wait a second. *(He listens.)* I hear His voice again. *(Saul listens intently Then he begins to have a conversation with God.)* What? Are you sure? But we worked on it all night... But Lord, it is so beautiful and these people have come today to hear your word...I understand, but...But...Wait...Don't leave me like this...Goodbye. Goodbye. *(He folds the paper up and looks sadly at the audience.)* I'm very sorry. I thought he wanted me to share his words with

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you today. That's why I rang the bell and asked you all to come. But it was my mistake. A misunderstanding, really. I just didn't...This letter that we worked so hard on last night, this perfect specimen of God's word... He says it is not time yet. It's a letter for the new millennium, He says and the new millennium just hasn't come yet. *(Saul looks out at the people.)* I guess you can all go home. I'm very sorry.

Don't despair. Keep your hearts and your ears open, God said to tell you that. His word will be known. Be ready when the time comes. But first there is much work for me to do.

He says I have to translate it into English immediately and send it to the people back home. He says the folks there need his message more than anything. But we in Venezuela will receive it too. Be ready for the day it comes. Be open to it.

You must leave now. I wish I could have read you the letter but I must obey God. I have to. You do understand, don't you? I have work to do. So much translation...and I have to finish my bath. The soap is beginning to itch.

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

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